

The Open Source Institution

Linux is being touted as the key to proper e-governance. The obvious cost benefits in terms of OS licenses and the savings in the hardware usage lifecycle are enormous. Slowly, institutions and state run offices are realising that the open source world is ideal for them. In fact, most of these offices are yet to be computerised, thus the so-called transition period does not apply here.

Educational institutions are also trying to push Free Open Source software into their labs. This is an extremely important move, and will ensure that people are not restricted to proprietary or open source solutions. This will also allow people to accept and implement more affordable computing solutions for cash strapped educational institutions.

administrator or the home user is mapping his uses of the system. There are advantages and disadvantages to both. If you need Office productivity software and Internet access, Linux can provide a cheaper solution without skimping on the features. But if you are a gamer, Windows becomes the preferred choice", says Trevor Warren.

To master Linux, you need to have sound knowledge of the Command Line. But for a regular employee, is this needed? Nowadays, most Linux distributions have a decent GUI environment. Thus, if you can provide basic training to a user to operate in the Linux environment, he or she will be able to achieve the same productivity as on a Windows machine, at a much lesser cost.

An employee perspective...

While corporate planning and a complete analysis of using Linux is pleasing to the ear, an employee or home user has a radically different approach to computing. The PC is just a tool after all, and getting the job done as quickly and efficiently as possible is all that matters. Employees still have to maintain their deadlines, and the 'if it isn't broken, don't try to fix it' attitude still prevails.

The situation is even worse for the home user. Unless you have a resident geek in your family, you will never consider running a different OS. To become the ideal choice for the home user, Linux needs to have simple installations, ease of use, availability of common applications and good support for games. Home users don't want to use the command line. Does Linux fulfil all of these demands? Not quite. Linux does not have a difficult installation, but it could be made a lot simpler. The ease of use is not quite up to Windows standards, and Linux game support is still in its infancy. Then why would a person switch to Linux? In such a case, low costs do not matter. What is the point in having a free OS that does not allow you to run *Quake III Arena* with ease? This also results in piracy.

Making a decision to move to an Open Source system or remaining with a proprietary solution is no laughing matter. It takes a great deal of time and research. But the move definitely pays off if you do your analysis well. Large corporations such as LIC and IDBI have definitely shown an interest in moving towards a more affordable computing system. This has resulted in conferences and talks between experts, corporations, academia and governments. But a proper and concrete platform for people to discuss the future of Linux in India is still missing. Only when this platform is built will the final piece in the puzzle fit in. 

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